

Consciousness and Experiential Absence

An Evidentiary Contract and Staged Experimental Program

1. Introduction

Consciousness science has become increasingly capable of detecting experience when ordinary waking report is unavailable. Serial awakenings probe experience during sleep; anesthesia permits controlled dissociations among responsiveness, memory, and report; covert paradigms reveal preserved capacities in behaviorally unresponsive patients; physiological measures increasingly discriminate states and candidate dimensions of consciousness; and advanced meditation provides endogenous transitions that can be sampled repeatedly within the same individual.¹ These advances have widened the empirical surface on which consciousness can be studied. They have not eliminated a narrower measurement problem: what would warrant the claim that no experience occurred during a particular passage?

This paper does not report such a passage. Under the evidentiary contract developed here, the current literature does not yet provide the negative experiential anchor required to establish one. Sleep supplies serious no-experience reports but leaves passage-specific memory and retrieval burdens. Brief meditative cessation supplies repeated endogenous transitions but not an independently adjudicated protected interval. Extended cessation provides a promising longer target while its present phenomenological classification remains methodologically dependent in the places that matter for negative standing. Anesthesia makes dissociations among experience, responsiveness, and later memory experimentally explicit. Covert and physiological measures increasingly strengthen detection and state characterization, but their non-detection does not yet provide a universal passage-level warrant for experiential absence. The present result is therefore not that experiential absence has been found. It is that the missing evidence can be specified closely enough to be tested.

¹ Federico Siclari, Jessica J. LaRocque, Bradley R. Postle, and Giulio Tononi, "Assessing Sleep Consciousness Within Subjects Using a Serial Awakening Paradigm," *Frontiers in Psychology* 4 (2013): 542, doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00542; Samuel I. Kronemer, Peter A. Bandettini, and Javier Gonzalez-Castillo, "Sleuthing Subjectivity: A Review of Covert Measures of Consciousness," *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 26 (2025): 476–496, doi:10.1038/s41583-025-00934-1; Ishan J. Bajwa et al., "A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation," *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z; Clarita Bonamino, Clara Hausen, and Matthew D. Sacchet, "Advanced Meditation, Sleep, and Consciousness Science: An Emerging Frontier," *Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews* 187 (2026): 106741, doi:10.1016/j.neubiorev.2026.106741.

The candidate object used to sharpen that problem is C3R: Consciousness as current experiential standing. At the declared scope, C3R asks one passage-level question: whether experience is currently instantiated for a particular consciousness-capable carrier. It keeps that target distinct from remembered content, report, behavioral responsiveness, physiological complexity, candidate mechanism, and the standing capacity of the carrier itself. C3R is not offered merely as a terminological definition. Its scientific value, if it survives testing, lies in permitting those neighboring quantities to vary without allowing any of them to decide the experiential question by default.

C3R was derived and pressure-tested within Structural Flow (SF), an open structural framework used here to discriminate the candidate object, its neighboring quantities, its failure condition, and the evidence required for adjudication. Readers do not need to adopt the broader framework in order to evaluate the consciousness-science argument. The present paper introduces only the SF structure needed to understand that derivational role; the public formal surface for this result is carried by the accompanying Consciousness contract and Universal Kernel package. In the primary paper, SF functions as the derivational backbone that narrows the scientific burden; the evidence still has to come from consciousness research.

The formalization is equally limited. An accompanying Lean implementation does not prove that C3R is empirically true, establish experiential absence, or convert structural coherence into evidence. It records the opposite boundary: the encoded object can be located while empirical placement remains unavailable because the required negative experiential witness is missing. The resulting disposition is NotYetAdjudicable. The exact Universal Kernel source, Consciousness contract/adaptor, source hashes, and execution information are part of the public package so that readers can rerun the formal object, inspect the encoding, alter assumptions, or try to break the relation themselves. A clean machine result establishes only that the encoded checkpoint is accepted at its declared formal scope and reaches the declared stop.

The empirical reason for that stop is an asymmetry between detecting experience and establishing its absence. A positive report, a prospective signal, or another independently validated positive indicator may establish experience within a bounded interval. Failure to obtain the same evidence does not automatically establish the reciprocal proposition. A person may experience without later retrieving the content; memory formation may be impaired; overt response may be unavailable; a candidate physiological marker may fail to appear; or the relevant event may be too poorly localized in time. Evidence of absence therefore requires more than absence of positive evidence.

That distinction motivates a three-stage experimental program. The negative report is first tested in independently known-positive cases under genuine memory or access challenge, so the unknown target does not validate its own negative instrument. Only after that burden is cleared is the instrument applied to prospectively bounded extended-cessation passages in qualified practitioners, with entry and exit uncertainty separated from an interior protected core and with memory, access, report competence, physiological evidence, and positive contradiction handled independently. The resulting evidence is then locked before a preregistered rule assigns experiential standing and determines whether any admissible NEGATIVE recurs strongly enough to constitute an anchor rather than an isolated event.

The program is designed to fail at identifiable loci. The negative instrument can fail validation. The target passage can fail construction. Extended cessation can fail as the selected route to experiential absence. Valid passages can remain INDETERMINATE. Repeated positive evidence can close the present target route. More fundamentally, C3R itself can be pressured if current experiential standing and an independently warranted same-level criterion for Consciousness come apart, or if the distinct job assigned to C3R is successfully absorbed by another object. The proposal is therefore not constructed so that every outcome supports the same conclusion.

The contribution of the present work is consequently narrower than a general theory of Consciousness or a solution to the neural basis of subjective experience. It is an attempt to make one difficult negative claim experimentally answerable without weakening it into non-response, non-recall, proxy non-detection, or a state label. Whether the same consciousness-capable carrier can traverse a prospectively bounded passage in which current experiential standing is absent remains an open empirical question. The purpose of this paper is to specify what would have to be observed before that answer could responsibly become yes.

2. Evidence of Absence Is Not Absence of Evidence

Consciousness is not observed from a single evidentiary surface. Depending on the experimental setting, researchers may use verbal report, instructed behavior, memory, physiological activity, covert task performance, or combinations of these measures to infer whether experience was present. These approaches have substantially expanded the study of consciousness beyond ordinary waking report. They also create a recurrent asymmetry. Evidence that successfully detects experience can establish its presence in a passage, whereas failure to obtain that evidence does not necessarily establish its absence. The missing signal may instead reflect the limitations of the measurement route.

This problem is especially important when the scientific claim concerns a bounded period rather than a broad state category. To say that a participant did not respond, did not later remember, or did not express a candidate physiological marker describes an observation. To say that no phenomenal experience occurred during the passage is a stronger claim about what the observation warrants. The two may coincide under an adequately validated measurement relation, but they should not be identified in advance.

2.1 Report and memory

First-person report is often the most direct available evidence about experience, but a report obtained after the target passage also depends on what remains accessible when the report is requested. Sleep research makes this distinction unusually visible. Serial-awakening studies have separated cases in which participants describe experiential content from cases in which they judge that experience occurred despite being unable to retrieve that content, and from cases in which they report no preceding experience.² The existence of the middle category matters because it shows that loss of reportable content and loss of experience are not experimentally interchangeable.

Later work reinforces the need to treat the report process itself as part of the measurement problem. Sleep reports depend both on what was experienced and on what was retained and retrieved, while carefully obtained null reports remain serious candidate evidence for unconscious sleep.³ Anesthesia makes the same inferential problem more acute because anesthetic drugs can impair memory formation as well as responsiveness and experience.⁴ Across both domains, the relevant point is not that no-experience reports are mistaken, but that retrospective silence can have more than one experimentally plausible source.

The relevant inference is narrow. Reports remain indispensable evidence about consciousness, including reports of apparent absence. The difficulty arises when absence of retrievable content, absence of later recall, or inability to report is treated as sufficient to

² Federico Siclari, Jessica J. LaRocque, Bradley R. Postle, and Giulio Tononi, "Assessing Sleep Consciousness Within Subjects Using a Serial Awakening Paradigm," *Frontiers in Psychology* 4 (2013): 542, doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00542.

³ Giulio Tononi, Melanie Boly, and Chiara Cirelli, "Consciousness and Sleep," *Neuron* 112(10) (2024): 1568–1594, doi:10.1016/j.neuron.2024.04.011; Benjamin Stucky, "We Are the Sensors of Consciousness! A Review and Analysis on How Awakenings During Sleep Influence Dream Recall," *Nature and Science of Sleep* 17 (2025): 709–729, doi:10.2147/NSS.S506461.

⁴ Kane O. Pryor, Yiping Jiang, and Jamie W. Sleight, "Anesthetic Amnesia: The Forgotten Importance of Forgetting?," *Anesthesiology* 143(3) (2025): 750–771, doi:10.1097/ALN.0000000000005544; David Lindsay, Ram Adapa, David K. Menon, and Emmanuel A. Stamatakis, "The Amnesic Effects of Propofol on Functional Connectivity in the Hippocampus Determined by Functional Magnetic Resonance Imaging in Volunteers," *British Journal of Anaesthesia* 135(4) (2025): 930–940, doi:10.1016/j.bja.2025.04.032; Ishan J. Bajwa et al., "A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation," *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z.

establish absence of experience. A negative inference needs to distinguish those possibilities rather than collapse them.

2.2 Responsiveness and behavioral silence

Behavior provides another powerful but incomplete route. Overt command following can establish capacities that are difficult to explain without substantial ongoing processing and, in suitable circumstances, may provide strong evidence relevant to consciousness. Failure to respond is more ambiguous because motor impairment, task failure, sensory limitations, sedation, or inability to convert an internal state into the required output can all suppress behavior without answering the experiential question.

Studies of connected consciousness during general anesthesia illustrate the asymmetry: command responses can occur during anesthesia despite weak or absent later explicit recall.⁵ Such findings do not establish that behaviorally unresponsive patients are generally conscious. They show that responsiveness, later memory, and current experience can dissociate strongly enough that one cannot automatically stand in for the others.

Behavioral silence is therefore evidence about behavior first. Under some validated conditions it may contribute to a broader inference about experiential state, but the absence of a response does not obtain negative phenomenological authority merely from the seriousness of the clinical or experimental condition in which it occurs. The same discipline applies in the opposite direction: a behavior interpreted as positive evidence must have a warranted relation to the experiential claim being made rather than being treated as conscious by definition.

2.3 Covert and physiological evidence

The development of covert and physiological measures has reduced dependence on overt report and behavior. Contemporary consciousness research uses electrophysiology, neuroimaging, perturbational measures, eye signals, cardiac and respiratory variables, autonomic responses, and covert task paradigms to characterize states and detect evidence that may not be behaviorally expressed.⁶ These approaches are especially important in sleep,

⁵ Richard Lennertz et al., “Connected Consciousness After Tracheal Intubation in Young Adults: An International Multicentre Cohort Study,” *British Journal of Anaesthesia* 130(2) (2023): e217–e224, doi:10.1016/j.bja.2022.04.010.

⁶ Samuel I. Kronemer, Peter A. Bandettini, and Javier Gonzalez-Castillo, “Sleuthing Subjectivity: A Review of Covert Measures of Consciousness,” *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 26 (2025): 476–496, doi:10.1038/s41583-025-00934-1; An-An Ping et al., “A Methodological Guideline for Consciousness Assessment via Neural Electrophysiological Activity,” *Military Medical Research* 12 (2025): 90, doi:10.1186/s40779-025-00682-4.

anesthesia, and disorders of consciousness, where ordinary report may be unavailable or unreliable.

Their growing power does not eliminate the inferential asymmetry. Different measures track different properties and perform differently across conditions, and current methodological work continues to emphasize cross-condition and multimodal validation rather than treating any single physiological quantity as a universal consciousness meter.⁷ Progress toward behavior-independent detection therefore sharpens rather than removes the methodological question: what inferential claim has a measure actually been validated to support, and does its absence warrant the reciprocal conclusion?

In the current literature considered here, we identified no validated universal third-person measure whose non-detection alone establishes that no phenomenal experience occurred during a particular passage. This is a bounded statement about present evidentiary validation, not a claim that such a measure is impossible or that physiological evidence is secondary to first-person evidence. A validated physiological positive may provide decisive evidence against whole-passage absence. Transition markers may improve temporal localization. Neural measurements may characterize mechanism and generate stronger future classifiers. What does not follow automatically is that failure to detect any one of these signals constitutes a negative experiential observation.

The common problem across report, memory, behavior, and physiology is therefore not that these measures are inadequate to consciousness science. It is that each measure must retain the inferential job it has actually earned. Positive evidence, negative evidence, and failure to obtain evidence are not interchangeable scientific objects. The remainder of this paper develops an explicit admission contract for keeping those objects separate at the level of a particular carrier and passage.

3. C3R and the Experiential Admission Contract

The empirical problem identified above requires a target more precise than a generic distinction between “conscious” and “unconscious.” Report, memory, responsiveness, physiological complexity, and experiential content can each vary without answering the same question. The candidate examined here therefore fixes the object at the level of a particular

⁷ An-An Ping et al., “A Methodological Guideline for Consciousness Assessment via Neural Electrophysiological Activity,” *Military Medical Research* 12 (2025): 90, doi:10.1186/s40779-025-00682-4; Ishan J. Bajwa et al., “A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation,” *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z; Tiziano Bertoni et al., “Multisensory Integration in Peripersonal Space Indexes Consciousness States in Sleep and Disorders of Consciousness,” *Cell Reports Medicine* 7 (2026): 102705, doi:10.1016/j.xcrm.2026.102705.

passage in a particular consciousness-capable system. We refer to this candidate as C3R: Consciousness as current experiential standing.

C3R is not offered merely as a lexical definition of consciousness. Its scientific job is to hold fixed one passage-level question that neighboring measures do not answer by themselves: whether experience is currently instantiated for this bearer during this passage. Under C3R, Consciousness is treated as the passage-specific held mode in which experiential standing is currently instantiated for the bearer. The formulation does not attempt to specify a universal neural mechanism, a biological substrate, the contents of experience, or the conditions under which a system becomes consciousness-capable in the first place. Its value, if it survives testing, lies in keeping the target variable distinct while report, memory, behavior, physiology, content, and candidate mechanisms are allowed to vary independently.

Two separations are essential to that job. The first is between current experiential standing and the standing capacity for Consciousness. A system may remain the same consciousness-capable carrier across a transition even if its current experiential mode changes. Without that distinction, the disappearance or destruction of the carrier itself could be mistaken for closure of a current experiential mode. The failure case relevant to C3R is narrower: standing capacity remains while current experiential standing closes.

The second separation is between experiential standing and experiential content. A person may judge that experience occurred while later being unable to retrieve what that experience contained. Sleep research provides familiar examples of this distinction, but the point is methodological rather than state-specific. Failure to retrieve content is not sufficient to establish that experience itself was absent. Conversely, the existence of a memory trace or later report is not required to define the current experiential mode. C3R therefore treats content, memory, and report as possible evidence about experiential standing rather than as substitutes for it.

The same discipline applies to behavioral and physiological variables. Responsiveness, wakefulness, neural complexity, integration, recurrence, connectivity, or another candidate mechanism may provide useful evidence about a passage. Some may eventually support strong positive inferences when independently validated for that purpose. None is identified with current experiential standing merely because it correlates with states commonly described as conscious or unconscious. The distinction matters most on the negative side, where absence of a response or marker can otherwise inherit more evidentiary force than its validation warrants.

3.1 Experiential standing

For a pinned carrier and passage, the present admission contract permits three experiential standings: POSITIVE, NEGATIVE, and INDETERMINATE. These terms describe evidentiary standing under the contract rather than ordinary-language state labels.

POSITIVE is available when admissible evidence warrants that experience was present in the passage. NEGATIVE requires admissible evidence that experience was absent. INDETERMINATE applies when the passage is sufficiently well defined to ask the question but the available evidence does not settle it under the contract. The third category is essential because the absence of evidence for one polarity does not supply evidence for the other. Failure to establish POSITIVE therefore does not become NEGATIVE, and failure to establish NEGATIVE does not become POSITIVE.

This three-way structure also prevents common proxies from deciding the question by default. No report, no movement, no command following, no later recall, or failure to detect a covert or physiological marker is insufficient on its own for NEGATIVE. Likewise, evidence that a system retains the capacity for Consciousness does not establish that current experiential standing is present inside the passage. Each observation retains the evidentiary job it has actually earned.

The negative burden is intentionally stricter because a later absence judgment can be produced by processes other than prior experiential absence. A passage classified NEGATIVE must therefore contain dedicated negative experiential evidence that is temporally attributable to the passage, sufficiently protected against memory and later-access explanations, independent of the candidate mechanism or state label under test, and free of unresolved contradictory positive evidence. If one of those burdens remains materially open, the appropriate standing is INDETERMINATE rather than a weaker form of NEGATIVE.

Candidate independence is especially important for states whose names already carry theoretical interpretation. A passage does not become experientially absent because it has been called “dreamless sleep,” “unconsciousness,” or “cessation of consciousness,” just as a physiological pattern does not become Consciousness merely because it has been proposed as a neural correlate. Such classifications may identify valuable experimental targets. The experiential standing of the passage must still be established by evidence that does not obtain its conclusion from the label being tested.

Temporal localization imposes a similar constraint. Evidence about experiential standing must apply to the passage for which the claim is made. If the relevant experience report, memory failure, physiological event, or transition cannot be located with sufficient

confidence inside that passage, the contract does not permit a more precise standing than the evidence supports. This is one reason the proposed experiment below uses a protected interior interval rather than treating an entire practice episode or transition as a single experiential object.

3.2 The present empirical burden

The current asymmetry between positive and negative evidence now becomes explicit. Positive experiential standing can be warranted in ordinary conditions in which a bearer directly affirms current experience while retaining sufficient report competence and temporal anchoring. No equivalent negative anchor has yet been identified that also clears the memory, access, temporal, contradiction, and candidate-independence burdens described above.

That missing anchor is the empirical burden carried forward in this paper. It is not a generic demand for stronger evidence of unconsciousness, nor does it require a single universal biomarker. The narrower question is whether the same consciousness-capable carrier can traverse a well-localized passage in which current experiential standing is absent while the surrounding evidence remains sufficient to distinguish that absence from forgetting, failed report, behavioral silence, later-access failure, proxy non-detection, or loss of the carrier itself.

C3R was derived and pressure-tested within Structural Flow (SF), an open structural framework used here to discriminate the candidate object, its neighboring quantities, its failure condition, and the evidence required to adjudicate it. The public formal burden used by this paper is carried in the accompanying Consciousness contract and Universal Kernel package; evaluating the empirical argument does not require access to, or acceptance of, the broader SF development record. The primary scientific consequence needed here is more limited: if C3R is the candidate object, empirical adjudication requires an admissible negative experiential anchor. The current literature does not yet provide one under the admission contract described here. Section 4 therefore asks how the strongest existing candidate-negative families fare when that same burden is applied consistently.

4. Current Empirical Adjudication

With the admission contract fixed, the relevant question is whether the strongest existing candidate-negative families already satisfy its passage-specific burden. The literature provides substantial evidence about experience, transitions, memory, physiology, and behavioral

responsiveness. The narrower issue is whether any current candidate also supplies the negative experiential anchor required for empirical adjudication of C3R.

4.1 Positive experiential standing

Positive experiential standing provides the reference case for the adjudication below. A time-pinned affirmative report from a bearer who can presently discriminate and report experience directly addresses whether experience is occurring, even though such evidence is neither infallible nor theory-free. Negative standing requires more because later silence can arise from failures of memory, access, behavior, measurement, or temporal localization without entailing experiential absence. The candidate-negative literatures below are therefore evaluated against the asymmetric burden established in Section 3.

4.2 NREM sleep and null reports

Serial-awakening studies provide one of the clearest demonstrations that experiential presence and later content availability should not be collapsed. Siclari and colleagues distinguished reports in which participants could describe a preceding conscious experience from reports in which participants judged that experience had occurred but could no longer retrieve its content, as well as from reports of no conscious experience.⁸ That separation is important for the present analysis because it shows that an absence of accessible content need not be treated as an absence of experience.

Sleep research also provides serious evidence for genuinely experience-free periods. A recent review by Tononi, Boly, and Cirelli treats carefully elicited null reports and dreamless sleep as informative evidence about unconscious states rather than merely assuming that every null report reflects forgetting.⁹ The present framework does not reject that interpretation. It applies a narrower admission question: whether a particular retrospective null report independently establishes experiential absence in the passage being classified.

That question remains nontrivial because sleep reports are also affected by the conditions under which they are obtained. Reviewing 69 awakening studies conducted between 2000 and 2024, Stucky found that reported experience varied with factors including the method of awakening, study duration and environment, and participant characteristics; recall during NREM sleep was especially sensitive to awakening procedure and interindividual

⁸ Federico Siclari, Jessica J. LaRocque, Bradley R. Postle, and Giulio Tononi, "Assessing Sleep Consciousness Within Subjects Using a Serial Awakening Paradigm," *Frontiers in Psychology* 4 (2013): 542, doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00542.

⁹ Giulio Tononi, Melanie Boly, and Chiara Cirelli, "Consciousness and Sleep," *Neuron* 112(10) (2024): 1568–1594, doi:10.1016/j.neuron.2024.04.011.

differences.¹⁰ These findings do not show that null reports are false. They show that the mapping from a preceding passage to a later report is itself experimentally conditioned.

Accordingly, NREM sleep provides scientifically important candidate-negative evidence, but a null report alone does not yet satisfy the present negative-admission burden. The literature establishes that no-experience reports occur and that within-state comparisons are tractable. It also establishes reasons to distinguish experiential absence from failure of retrieval or report. Until those alternatives are sufficiently controlled for a temporally pinned passage, NREM null reports remain INDETERMINATE with respect to the C3R negative anchor.

4.3 Brief meditative cessation

Brief meditative cessation offers a different advantage: repeated endogenous events can be sampled within the same highly trained individual while physiological activity is recorded around the event. In an intensively sampled case study, Chowdhury and colleagues identified recurrent cessation events accompanied by peri-event spectral changes.¹¹ A subsequent network analysis examined 37 selected cessation events collected from one advanced meditator across 29 sessions and found a progressive decrease in large-scale alpha-band functional connectivity before the event followed by recovery afterward.¹² Together, these studies show that meditation-associated cessation events can support repeated physiological measurement around a relatively sharp transition.

That result is valuable without requiring the event label to settle the experiential question. The studies identify their events through a neurophenomenological procedure in which the trained participant's characterization of cessation contributes materially to event selection. The source literature itself describes cessation in strong experiential terms, including discontinuation of experience. Those descriptions are part of the empirical record, but they do not independently establish the passage-level NEGATIVE classification used here.

The temporal geometry is also important. Existing brief-cessation work was designed to characterize changes around cessation events, not to construct a prospectively bounded interior passage whose entire duration can be adjudicated for experiential absence while memory and later access are separately controlled. Thus, brief cessation has already

¹⁰ Benjamin Stucky, "We Are the Sensors of Consciousness! A Review and Analysis on How Awakenings During Sleep Influence Dream Recall," *Nature and Science of Sleep* 17 (2025): 709–729, doi:10.2147/NSS.S506461.

¹¹ Anindita Chowdhury et al., "Investigation of Advanced Mindfulness Meditation 'Cessation' Experiences Using EEG Spectral Analysis in an Intensively Sampled Case Study," *Neuropsychologia* 190 (2023): 108694, doi:10.1016/j.neuropsychologia.2023.108694.

¹² Remko van Lutterveld, Anindita Chowdhury, Daniel M. Ingram, and Matthew D. Sacchet, "Neurophenomenological Investigation of Mindfulness Meditation 'Cessation' Experiences Using EEG Network Analysis in an Intensively Sampled Adept Meditator," *Brain Topography* 37 (2024): 849–858, doi:10.1007/s10548-024-01052-4.

established something useful and nontrivial: repeated transition-linked physiology in an endogenous target state. What it has not yet established is the independent negative experiential standing of a protected passage. For the present purpose, brief cessation therefore functions as a transition model rather than an earned negative anchor.

4.4 Extended meditative cessation

Recent work on extended meditative cessation changes the experimental opportunity. Unlike the brief events above, extended cessation offers candidate intervals long enough to support stronger prospective temporal control, memory testing, and within-carrier comparison. Current evidence remains preliminary: the principal empirical studies are preprints. Nevertheless, they show that extended cessation can be studied in the laboratory using multiple neuroimaging and electrophysiological modalities.

Yang and colleagues used ultra-high-field 7T fMRI with dense within-subject sampling in three advanced meditators.¹³ Their participants attempted extended cessation during imaging, but the study also exposes the temporal problem directly. Some participants indicated that they could not self-report the moment of entry, so entry was not prospectively marked in those cases and its duration was estimated retrospectively. Phenomenology was collected after the meditation task, and two participants provided those responses after formal data collection had concluded. The authors report the state in strong terms, including suspension or absence of consciousness. Under the present admission contract, however, those source-level interpretations do not by themselves establish that a prospectively identified passage satisfies NEGATIVE experiential standing.

Other recent preprints broaden the feasibility case. Shinozuka and colleagues have reported multimodal EEG/MEG measurements in five meditators, while Zarka and colleagues used dense-sampling EEG microstate analysis in five highly trained practitioners.¹⁴ These studies are important because the experimental object is no longer confined to a single intensively sampled individual or a single measurement modality. Extended cessation is becoming a repeatable laboratory target across participants and methods.

That progress makes extended cessation more attractive as an experiment, but it does not remove the evidentiary gap. The current studies were not designed to validate an independent negative-report instrument before applying it to cessation, to construct a

¹³ Winson F. Z. Yang et al., “Endogenous Suspension and Reset of Consciousness: 7T fMRI Brain Mapping of the Extended Cessation Meditative Endpoint,” *bioRxiv* (2025), preprint, doi:10.1101/2025.09.06.674021.

¹⁴ Kenneth Shinozuka et al., “Neuroelectrophysiological Correlates of Extended Cessation of Consciousness in Advanced Meditators: A Multimodal EEG and MEG Study,” *bioRxiv* (2025), preprint, doi:10.1101/2025.09.19.677455; David Zarka et al., “EEG Brain Reconfiguration During Meditation-Induced Extended Cessation of Consciousness: A Dense-Sampling Multi-Participant Microstate Study,” *bioRxiv* (2026), preprint, doi:10.64898/2026.02.10.705005.

prospectively protected adjudication core, or to require the memory/access and positive-contradiction controls specified by the present admission contract. Their results therefore support feasibility and target selection rather than retrospective promotion to NEGATIVE.

Extended cessation is consequently the leading target paradigm for the proposed experiment precisely because its experiential standing remains open. It combines endogenous and reversible state entry with longer candidate passages and increasing multimodal tractability, while avoiding a primary pharmacological intervention that is itself expected to impair memory. The experiment proposed below does not assume that extended cessation is experientially absent. It asks whether that claim can be earned prospectively.

4.5 Anesthesia and amnesia

General anesthesia offers stronger external control of state transitions than meditation, but it also makes the memory problem unusually explicit. Anesthetic drugs can alter consciousness, responsiveness, and memory through partially dissociable processes. A recent review argues that anesthetic impairment of consciousness does not invariably entail complete experiential absence and that apparent absence may sometimes reflect amnesia rather than absence of subjective experience.¹⁵ Propofol, in particular, can substantially impair memory formation, including through effects involving hippocampal systems.¹⁶

Prospective studies also show why later explicit recall cannot safely serve as the sole negative criterion. Using the isolated forearm technique, Lennertz and colleagues observed responses consistent with connected consciousness after tracheal intubation in 37 of 338 young adults, or 11% of the cohort, despite the rarity of later explicit recall as a clinical outcome.¹⁷ Such findings do not imply that patients under general anesthesia are generally conscious. They demonstrate that behavioral unresponsiveness, later recall, and contemporaneous evidence of experience can dissociate.

A repeated-awakening propofol study makes the same problem visible within a tightly controlled sedated state. Across 52 attempted awakenings, Bajwa and colleagues obtained 24 reports of preceding experience and five reports of no experience; in the remaining 23 attempts, participants were either not arousable or unable to provide a sufficiently coherent

¹⁵ Kane O. Pryor, Yiping Jiang, and Jamie W. Sleight, “Anesthetic Amnesia: The Forgotten Importance of Forgetting?,” *Anesthesiology* 143(3) (2025): 750–771, doi:10.1097/ALN.0000000000005544.

¹⁶ David Lindsay, Ram Adapa, David K. Menon, and Emmanuel A. Stamatakis, “The Amnesic Effects of Propofol on Functional Connectivity in the Hippocampus Determined by Functional Magnetic Resonance Imaging in Volunteers,” *British Journal of Anaesthesia* 135(4) (2025): 930–940, doi:10.1016/j.bja.2025.04.032.

¹⁷ Richard Lennertz et al., “Connected Consciousness After Tracheal Intubation in Young Adults: An International Multicentre Cohort Study,” *British Journal of Anaesthesia* 130(2) (2023): e217–e224, doi:10.1016/j.bja.2022.04.010.

report about the preceding period.¹⁸ Two EEG complexity measures—state-transition perturbational complexity and single-channel Lempel-Ziv complexity—distinguished wakefulness from deep propofol sedation but did not distinguish reported dreaming from reported non-dreaming within the sedated state.

For the present project, anesthesia therefore performs a different experimental job from extended cessation. It is a strong adversarial domain for testing whether a negative-report instrument mistakes impaired memory or access for experiential absence. Its pharmacological amnesia burden, however, makes it less suitable as the primary passage in which to seek the negative anchor itself. Anesthesia is retained as a validation and false-negative pressure family, not because it cannot produce unconsciousness, but because later no-recall is insufficient to establish when experiential standing was absent.

4.6 Covert and physiological measures

The increasing sophistication of physiological and covert measures makes it especially important not to frame the present argument as a rejection of third-person consciousness science. Neural, autonomic, ocular, and other covert signals can provide information that overt behavior cannot. Kronemer and colleagues review a rapidly expanding set of measures capable of detecting dimensions or correlates of consciousness when ordinary report is absent or unreliable.¹⁹ Recent methodological work similarly emphasizes a growing electrophysiological toolkit while cautioning that different measures track different dimensions and require further cross-condition validation.²⁰

New empirical work continues to improve this landscape. Bertoni and colleagues reported a high-beta peripersonal-space index that was present during wakefulness and dreaming but absent during dreamless sleep, correlated with behavioral measures of consciousness in patients with disorders of consciousness, and predicted clinical recovery.²¹ Such results are directly relevant to the problem addressed here because they move consciousness assessment toward behavior-independent detection. They are not reasons to discount physiological evidence; they are reasons to specify its inferential role carefully.

¹⁸ Ishan J. Bajwa et al., “A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation,” *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z.

¹⁹ Samuel I. Kronemer, Peter A. Bandettini, and Javier Gonzalez-Castillo, “Sleuthing Subjectivity: A Review of Covert Measures of Consciousness,” *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 26 (2025): 476–496, doi:10.1038/s41583-025-00934-1.

²⁰ An-An Ping et al., “A Methodological Guideline for Consciousness Assessment via Neural Electrophysiological Activity,” *Military Medical Research* 12 (2025): 90, doi:10.1186/s40779-025-00682-4.

²¹ Tiziano Bertoni et al., “Multisensory Integration in Peripersonal Space Indexes Consciousness States in Sleep and Disorders of Consciousness,” *Cell Reports Medicine* 7 (2026): 102705, doi:10.1016/j.xcrm.2026.102705.

The asymmetry appears when a marker is absent. A signal that has been validated as evidence of current experience may, when present, contradict a proposed whole-passage NEGATIVE classification. Its non-detection does not automatically carry the reciprocal proposition that no experience occurred. The Bajwa propofol findings illustrate the problem: complexity measures that separated wakefulness from deep sedation did not distinguish reported dreaming from reported non-dreaming within sedation.²² State discrimination and passage-specific experiential classification are not necessarily the same measurement problem.

In the literature reviewed here, we identified no presently validated universal third-person readout whose absence alone warrants the proposition that no phenomenal experience occurred during a specific passage. This is a bounded statement about current validation, not a claim that such a measure is impossible. Physiological evidence therefore remains central to the proposed program for transition localization, mechanistic characterization, quality control, and—where independently warranted—positive contradiction. What it does not do by default is convert non-detection into NEGATIVE standing.

4.7 Current empirical disposition

The candidate families fail the present negative burden for different reasons, so their evidence should not be treated as interchangeable. Table 1 summarizes what each family presently establishes, the burden that remains open, and the experimental role it can nevertheless perform.

Table 1. Current candidate-negative adjudication

Candidate family	What the current evidence establishes	Primary unresolved burden	Current C3R standing as a negative anchor	Experimental role
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²² Ishan J. Bajwa et al., “A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation,” *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z.

NREM / sleep	No-experience reports occur; experience without retrievable content can be distinguished; within-state contrasts are experimentally tractable	Passage-specific separation of experiential absence from memory/retrieval and sampling effects	INDETERMINATE	Calibration and comparison family
Brief meditative cessation	Repeated endogenous events and reproducible peri-event EEG changes can be measured	Independent negative classification and a prospectively bounded passage suitable for whole-core adjudication	INDETERMINATE	Transition model
Extended meditative cessation	Longer reversible candidate passages are laboratory-tractable across participants and multiple modalities	Prospective entry/exit bounds, independently validated negative datum, memory/access control, and protected-core adjudication	INDETERMINATE; NEGATIVE not earned	Leading target paradigm

General anesthesia	Controlled transitions, amnesia effects, connected-consciousness dissociations, and repeated-awakening paradigms are experimentally accessible	Pharmacological memory impairment prevents later no-recall from serving as a stand-alone negative criterion	INDETERMINATE as a negative anchor	Adversarial memory / false-negative validation family
Covert / physiological measures	Increasingly strong state discrimination, covert detection, mechanistic characterization, and prognostic information	No reviewed measure is presently validated such that non-detection alone universally warrants passage-specific experiential absence	No NEGATIVE from non-detection alone	Positive contradiction, transition localization, mechanism, and support

The present empirical stop is therefore narrower than a claim that consciousness science lacks evidence of unconscious states. The field already contains sophisticated evidence about reported absence, reduced or absent responsiveness, memory disruption, physiological state changes, and candidate biomarkers. The unresolved issue is whether any presently available candidate passage satisfies the specific evidentiary requirements needed to infer experiential absence while excluding the principal alternative routes to the same observed silence. Under the admission contract used here, none yet does. The resulting absence of a negative anchor is therefore an evidentiary gap to be tested, not a negative result in favor of C3R.

5. The Formal Stop and the Missing Witness

The preceding adjudication leaves C3R in an unusual but scientifically useful position. Its structural object can be stated and its evidentiary requirements can be made explicit, yet the empirical evidence presently available does not satisfy the negative side of that contract. The formal question is therefore not whether the missing evidence can be inferred from what is already known. It is whether the architecture preserves that absence as an unresolved burden.

The machine-checked implementation does. In the frozen Consciousness workbench, the object-level job, shape, and failure are represented as located, while empirical placement remains unavailable because the current evidence ledger contains no admitted NEGATIVE experiential anchor. The corresponding compatibility test against the Universal Kernel returns the formal disposition NotYetAdjudicable. In ordinary scientific terms, the formal system reaches the point at which a negative experiential witness is required and stops because that witness is not present.

This result is deliberately weaker than empirical support for C3R. A clean formal check establishes that the encoded relations are internally admissible at their declared scope; it does not establish that the empirical premises are true, that the admission contract is complete, or that Consciousness is in fact identical to current experiential standing. The machine neither observes the candidate passages nor supplies the phenomenological evidence needed to classify them. Its contribution is instead procedural: once the missing empirical burden has been represented explicitly, the formal architecture does not permit an open burden to be treated as though it had been discharged.

The formal claim is also intended to be independently inspectable rather than accepted as a black box. The public package includes the exact Universal Kernel source, the Consciousness contract/adaptor, source identities and hashes, and the relevant execution environment. A reader can rerun the files, inspect the encoding, modify assumptions, or attempt to produce a counterexample or failed formal relation. A failure at that layer would pressure the encoding or the formal claim it represents; a clean run still would not convert the formal result into empirical evidence.

The same formal separation applies to the Universal Kernel and to mechanism. The unresolved empirical burden is not a known failure of the shared formal interface and does not require kernel modification for this case; that does not imply kernel completeness or that Consciousness has been derived from the kernel. Nor must the neural or physical realization of current experiential standing be solved before passage-level standing can be tested. Mechanism and experiential adjudication remain distinct open questions.

What remains missing is therefore more specific than additional evidence in general. The required witness is a passage in the same consciousness-capable carrier for which current experiential standing can be assigned NEGATIVE while the standing capacity relevant to C3R remains sufficiently warranted and the principal alternative explanations for apparent absence have been controlled. The passage must be temporally identified, the negative experiential evidence must apply to the passage itself, memory and later-access failure must

not remain an adequate explanation, the classification must not inherit its answer from the state or mechanism under test, and admissible positive evidence must not remain unresolved.

No candidate reviewed in Section 4 presently supplies that combination. This is why the absence of a negative anchor should not be read as evidence in favor of C3R. It is the reason empirical adjudication cannot yet proceed. The formal result makes that limitation explicit rather than allowing structural coherence, suggestive physiology, or a persuasive state label to substitute for the missing observation.

The scientific consequence is nevertheless constructive. Once the unresolved burden has been narrowed to a passage-specific negative experiential anchor, the next question is no longer simply how to collect more data about states associated with reduced or absent consciousness. It is how to construct an experiment in which experiential absence could be earned without being assumed. That requirement determines the logic of the staged program developed below.

6. Why the Experiment Must Be Staged

The missing negative witness cannot be sought safely in a single target experiment. The central difficulty is that the proposed target state is precisely where experiential standing is unknown. If a participant emerges from extended cessation and reports complete experiential absence, that response may be the datum of interest, but the target trial itself cannot establish that the response reliably distinguishes prior absence from prior experience followed by loss of access. Using the same unknown cases both to validate the meaning of the negative response and to treat that response as evidence of absence would make the critical inference circular.

The negative instrument must therefore be tested before it is allowed to classify the target state. This requires passages in which prior experience has been established independently of the later report. If a participant can undergo a known-positive experience, encounter a genuine challenge to later memory or content access, and still distinguish “experience occurred but content is unavailable” from “no experience occurred,” then the negative response has survived the principal error for which the target experiment needs protection. If it cannot survive that test, the target study has no warranted basis for treating the same response as evidence of experiential absence.

Independent validation is necessary but not sufficient. Once the reporting instrument has cleared that burden, the experiment must still construct a target passage whose temporal boundaries are fixed without using the desired experiential outcome to define them. The

target state is therefore observed prospectively, with entry and exit uncertainty separated from an interior protected core. Memory and access are assessed around that passage, and physiological measurements remain available for transition localization, mechanistic characterization, and independently warranted positive contradiction without becoming the default negative classifier.

A final separation is required between collecting those data and deciding what they mean. If boundaries, exclusions, report criteria, memory requirements, or physiological thresholds can be changed after the target results are known, the experiment can gradually adapt itself to the observations it is supposed to adjudicate. The standing rule must therefore be fixed before the target evidence is interpreted and then applied to the locked record without retrospective rescue.

These requirements produce a three-stage program for methodological rather than administrative reasons. Stage A prevents the unknown target from validating its own negative report; Stage B constructs the target passage without using experiential standing to define it; and Stage C applies a frozen rule to locked evidence so that observed outcomes cannot alter the criteria by which they acquire standing. Only after those separations are in place does it become meaningful to ask whether a candidate passage supplies the negative experiential witness presently missing from C3R.

7. Stage A: Validating the Negative Instrument

Stage A operationalizes the first separation by testing the negative report before it is used in extended cessation. Its question is whether the instrument can distinguish experiential absence from the memory and access failures that could otherwise turn a known-positive experience into a false negative.

The instrument separates five judgments about a preceding passage. Category A indicates experience with at least some retrievable content. Category B indicates that experience is judged to have occurred even though its content is no longer retrievable. Category C indicates minimal or content-poor experiential presence. Category D is a judgment of complete experiential absence. Category E records that the participant cannot determine whether experience was present. The critical distinction is between D and the neighboring responses. A participant who has lost content but retains a sense that experience occurred should have B available; a participant who recalls only minimal presence should have C; and a participant for whom the evidence is insufficient should have E. D is reserved for the stronger judgment that no experience was present.

This taxonomy does not make D true by definition. Stage A is designed specifically to measure how often D appears when prior experience is independently known to have occurred. Its primary quantity is therefore

$$q_D = P(D \mid \text{prior positive experience independently established}).$$

The relevant error is narrow: an episode known to have contained experience is later classified as complete experiential absence. That is the error that would contaminate the proposed negative anchor if impaired memory or access could routinely transform prior experience into a D response.

The primary validation design uses one predesignated index passage from each independent participant. The current operating point requires 93 valid index cases and evaluates the observed false-D count using a one-sided 95% exact Clopper–Pearson upper confidence bound. The instrument passes this gate only if the upper bound for q_D is below 0.05. At $N = 93$, zero false-D responses yield an upper bound of approximately 0.0317, and one yields an upper bound of approximately 0.0500; two raise it to approximately 0.0662. Thus zero or one false-D response can satisfy the preregistered criterion, whereas two or more fail it. The five-percent tolerance is a prospective design choice intended to require a low false-D rate while keeping independent-participant validation operationally tractable; it is not uniquely privileged and is not a consequence of C3R or Structural Flow. A laboratory could preregister a stricter operating point, but the confirmatory threshold must be fixed before validation outcomes are known rather than selected retrospectively.

Repeated validation trials can provide additional information about individual heterogeneity and response stability, but they do not increase the primary independent-participant count. Such data would be analyzed secondarily using a model appropriate for clustered binary observations rather than treated as additional independent demonstrations of validity. This separation prevents intensive sampling of a small number of people from creating the appearance of broader validation.

The exact Stage-A paradigm remains open because the experiment architecture specifies the methodological job rather than prejudging the best laboratory implementation. A suitable paradigm must independently establish that experience is occurring and then place later memory or content access under genuine pressure before administering the A–E classification. Real-time dream communication offers one possible family because ongoing experience can sometimes be established prospectively during REM sleep before later recall

is assessed.²³ Connected-consciousness paradigms during anesthesia offer another possibility because contemporaneous responses can coexist with weak or absent later explicit recall. A different platform could serve the same function if it independently establishes prior experience and creates a meaningful memory/access challenge. Methodologically unlike paradigms would not be pooled merely to reach the required sample size.

Stage A can therefore fail in a scientifically decisive way. If the false-D criterion is not met, D does not enter the target study as a validated negative datum under the present instrument. Failure would not show that experiential absence is impossible, nor would it adjudicate C3R. It would show that the proposed instrument cannot yet distinguish absence from the memory/access failure it was designed to resist. Likewise, insufficient valid evidence would place the program on hold rather than count as validation by default.

Validation at the group level is not the only safeguard. Before a target participant can contribute a D response to the confirmatory negative route, that participant must also demonstrate personal use of the taxonomy. The current design requires known-positive but content-degraded calibration trials to be classified as B rather than D, minimal-positive trials to be distinguished as C, and genuinely unresolved trials to elicit E. A required known-positive calibration trial classified as D closes that participant's confirmatory negative route under the current rule. The participant may still contribute useful physiological or feasibility data, but subsequent target responses are not permitted to repair the failed calibration retrospectively.

Stage A therefore performs one job: it tests whether the negative experiential datum is sufficiently resistant to a predeclared class of known-positive memory/access failures to be used prospectively. Passing Stage A does not establish that D is a universally valid indicator of experiential absence, nor does it eliminate target-specific memory mechanisms in extended cessation. It clears one necessary error route before transfer to the target study. Participant-level calibration and the Stage-B memory/access guard remain required because that transfer is conditional rather than assumed. Only if the Stage-A burden is discharged does the program proceed to passages in which experiential absence is genuinely unknown.

8. Stage B: Prospectively Bounded Target Passages

Stage B applies the validated instrument to the leading target paradigm: repeated extended meditative cessation in qualified advanced practitioners. The selection of extended cessation

²³ Karen R. Konkoly et al., “Real-Time Dialogue Between Experimenters and Dreamers During REM Sleep,” *Current Biology* 31(7) (2021): 1417–1427.e6, doi:10.1016/j.cub.2021.01.026; Karen R. Konkoly et al., “Using Real-time Reporting to Investigate Visual Experiences in Dreams,” *Journal of Cognitive Neuroscience* 38(2) (2026): 365–380, doi:10.1162/JOCN.a.107.

does not assign it a negative experiential standing. It identifies a reversible endogenous condition in which sufficiently long candidate passages may be constructed between independently warranted positive experiential states, without introducing a primary pharmacological manipulation expected to produce amnesia.

Each target trial is a prospectively bounded extended-cessation attempt. Immediately before entry, the participant provides a current positive experiential anchor and engages sufficiently with the protocol to establish report competence. The participant then attempts the target practice, signals entry and exit prospectively to the degree required by the final timing implementation, and provides a second positive anchor after recovery. The experimental shape is therefore not “consciousness followed by unconsciousness.” It is a positive state, a candidate passage whose standing is unknown, and a subsequent positive state in the same identified carrier.

The target passage is narrower than the entire practice episode. Entry and exit are treated as uncertainty intervals rather than exact instants. If the entry interval is $E_i = [e_i^-, e_i^+]$ and the exit interval is $X_i = [x_i^-, x_i^+]$, the passage eligible for adjudication must lie strictly inside those bounds. The protected core P_i therefore begins after the latest plausible entry time and ends before the earliest plausible exit time, with any additional preregistered guard margins applied prospectively. If those constraints leave no non-empty protected core, the trial contains no negative-eligible passage. Retrospective reconstruction is not permitted to create one after the outcome is known.

This protected-core requirement separates passage identification from Consciousness classification. Physiological transition markers may help characterize entry and exit, and first-person signals may contribute to their prospective localization, but neither determines the experiential standing of the interior passage. That standing is adjudicated separately. The distinction matters because a target condition can be experimentally well localized without the experiment yet knowing whether experience was present within it.

For the resulting passage to bear on C3R, the same consciousness-capable carrier must also remain the relevant object across the transition. Capacity continuity is therefore warranted through a bounded empirical package: the same carrier remains identified; no destructive or substitutive event replaces it; entry and exit are reversible; positive experiential standing is re-established afterward; and the surrounding organization remains sufficiently intact to interpret the candidate event as closure of a current mode rather than dissolution of the carrier. These conditions do not claim direct metaphysical observation of a latent capacity. They establish the weakest experimental continuity needed for the C3R failure question.

The principal remaining threat is that a D response could still be produced by selective failure of memory or later access during the protected core. Stage B therefore surrounds the experiential judgment with an independent memory/access architecture. Before entry, the participant encodes a randomized neutral bridge token and receives a simple prospective post-exit instruction. After recovery, the protocol tests the bridge, execution of the prospective task, immediate report competence, and the ability to encode new information after the target state. It also verifies that the participant retains the trial identity and the distinction among content loss, minimal presence, uncertainty, and complete absence. These bookends are designed to detect broad memory, access, and report failures capable of explaining a D response.

The design does not claim that such tests logically eliminate every possible form of selective amnesia. A residual alternative remains: experience could occur specifically within the protected core while the target state selectively prevents later access both to its content and to the meta-memory that experience occurred, even though memory and report functions appear intact around it. The contract therefore distinguishes a merely conceivable alternative from an empirically live competing explanation. Logical possibility alone does not block adjudication indefinitely; independent evidence that materially supports target-specific selective amnesia does. If such evidence is present, NEGATIVE becomes unavailable until the conflict is resolved. The memory guard is therefore a falsifiable evidentiary burden rather than a declaration that forgetting has been made impossible.

The same asymmetry governs any optional stimulus or covert measure placed inside the protected core. A low-burden sentinel may be used only if prior calibration shows that it does not disrupt or redefine the target condition. Valid later evidence that the participant consciously experienced such a sentinel within P_i would contradict whole-core experiential absence. Failure to report it would not supply negative evidence. Likewise, a covert physiological or task-based measure can contribute positive evidence only if its warrant for current experience has been established independently of the target study. Processing without such a warrant remains processing evidence rather than a Consciousness classification.

The current Stage-B design enrolls 20 qualified practitioners. Each contributes six primary attempts distributed across three sessions, with two primary attempts per session. Up to two additional attempts per participant may replace trials that meet preregistered INVALID or EXCLUDE criteria, producing a maximum of eight attempts per carrier. POSITIVE, NEGATIVE, and INDETERMINATE trials are not replaced merely to create another opportunity for a preferred outcome, and data collection does not stop early because the

desired number of negatives has appeared. The fixed design preserves the denominator needed to interpret both success and failure.

Measurement is organized around the passage rather than around any single candidate biomarker. High-density EEG is synchronized with ocular, cardiorespiratory, movement, and event-timing channels, while direct experiential reports and the memory/access measures remain separate evidentiary objects. Additional imaging or stimulation methods may characterize physiology if available, but the confirmatory standing does not depend on promoting any one physiological feature into a definition of NEGATIVE. The intended public inference runs in the other direction: if a passage independently earns a standing, its physiology can then be characterized as physiology associated with that adjudicated passage.

Stage B therefore creates the evidentiary object that existing cessation studies do not yet provide: a prospectively constructed interior passage whose experiential standing can be asked independently of the state name, boundary reconstruction, or physiological pattern used to study it. Once the planned target program is complete, those data are locked before standing is computed.

9. Stage C: Locked Adjudication and Anchor Computation

Stage C separates data collection from the final classification of the target passages. After the Stage-B dataset is locked, adjudicators apply the preregistered rule to the evidence already collected. No new primary target trials are added because the existing results are disappointing, and Stage C does not repair failed boundaries, alter the report taxonomy, change the Stage-A error threshold, introduce new biomarker cutoffs, modify exclusions, or revise the recurrence criterion. A material change to one of those elements ends confirmatory interpretation under the frozen branch and requires a new prospective version of the protocol.

Where feasible, adjudicators receive only the information required to apply the standing rule: passage-validity status, coded experiential evidence, temporal support, the basis and coverage of any D response, memory/access status, positive-contradiction evidence, protocol-integrity information, capacity-continuity evidence, and associated reason codes. Investigator preference, rhetorical target-state labels, exploratory physiology, and prior trial outcomes are withheld when they are unnecessary to the adjudication. Blinding does not make the decision theory-free; it limits the opportunities for outcome knowledge to alter the rule by which the evidence is interpreted.

For an individual protected core, NEGATIVE is available only under the following conjunction:

$$\text{NEGATIVE}(P_i) \Leftrightarrow \text{VALID_PASSAGE}_i \wedge \text{MODE_CLASS}_i = D \wedge \text{CORE_COVERAGE}_i = \text{WHOLE} \wedge \text{D_BASIS_VALID}_i \wedge \text{M_GUARD}_i = \text{PASS} \wedge \text{POS_CONTRA}_i = \text{ABSENT} \wedge \text{CANDIDATE_INDEPENDENCE}_i = \text{PASS} \wedge \text{PROTOCOL_VALID}_i = \text{PASS}.$$

Only the D judgment is the dedicated negative experiential datum. The remaining terms perform different evidentiary jobs: they establish passage validity, protect against memory/access explanations, prevent contradictory positive evidence from being ignored, and preserve candidate independence and protocol integrity. Treating these heterogeneous safeguards as “multiple independent measures of unconsciousness” would therefore misstate the design.

Whole-core absence also creates an intentionally asymmetric precedence rule. The proposition being tested is that no experience occurred anywhere throughout P_i . Admissible positive evidence located within that interval is sufficient to defeat that whole-core proposition. Direct A, B, or C evidence attributable to the core therefore yields POSITIVE standing for the whole-core question, as does another independently validated positive route that genuinely warrants current experiential standing within the passage. A weaker physiological signal may create a material conflict and leave the passage INDETERMINATE, but a null signal never acquires the opposite authority merely because a valid positive was not found.

INDETERMINATE remains an affirmative scientific classification of unresolved standing rather than a residual bin for inconvenient trials. It applies when the passage itself is sufficiently valid to ask the question but the evidence does not settle it under the contract—for example, when the participant chooses E, when a D judgment covers only part of the protected core, when temporal attribution remains uncertain, when the memory/access burden fails or remains open, or when admissible positive and negative evidence conflict without a governing precedence route. INVALID or EXCLUDE is different: it applies when the passage or protocol fails before experiential standing can properly be adjudicated. A trial cannot become NEGATIVE merely because it is difficult to classify.

An admissible event-level NEGATIVE is itself not yet the study-level negative anchor. To contribute to C3R, the passage must also satisfy the required capacity-continuity burden. The current within-carrier rule then requires at least three distinct admissible NEGATIVE protected cores across at least two experimental sessions in the same qualified carrier. The

rule is a replication guard against one-off classification, passage, or session error; it is not an assertion that repeated trials within a participant are statistically independent.

One carrier satisfying that recurrence requirement provides a negative experiential anchor at a narrow existence-and-recurrence scope: the same consciousness-capable carrier has repeatedly traversed passages adjudicated NEGATIVE for current experiential standing between positive experiential states under the frozen evidentiary burden. Replication across at least two independent carriers strengthens the result against idiosyncrasy and provides the program's replicated C3R negative anchor. Neither result estimates how frequently the phenomenon occurs in meditators or humans generally, and neither establishes a universal neural mechanism.

The program can terminate with scientifically distinct outcomes that bear on different parts of the architecture rather than collapsing onto a single evidentiary axis. Table 2 fixes the permitted interpretation of those outcomes; Section 10 then separates their corresponding failure loci.

Table 2. Primary adjudication outcomes

Outcome	What it means under the frozen rule	Permitted conclusion	Prohibited overread
POSITIVE	Admissible evidence places current experiential standing within the protected core	Whole-core experiential absence is defeated for that passage	The target paradigm can never contain a NEGATIVE passage
NEGATIVE event	One protected core satisfies the full negative conjunction	One admissible passage-level negative occurred	A study-level C3R anchor has been established
INDETERMINATE	The standing question is valid but the evidence does not resolve it under the contract	Experiential standing remains unresolved for the passage	Experience was absent, probably absent, or present

INVALID / EXCLUDE	Required passage or protocol validity failed	The trial does not enter standing adjudication	The failed trial is evidence for either experiential polarity
STOP / HOLD	A governing program-level burden failed or could not yet be adjudicated	The current confirmatory branch cannot proceed under the frozen rule	C3R has thereby been falsified or validated
Within-carrier anchor	At least three admissible NEGATIVE cores occur across at least two sessions in one qualified carrier with capacity continuity	Recurrent negative experiential standing is established at narrow within-carrier scope	Population prevalence or universal biology has been established
Replicated anchor	At least two independent carriers satisfy the within-carrier rule	The negative anchor is replicated across independent carriers	The phenomenon is universal, common, or mechanistically explained

Stage C is therefore not an exercise in finding the classification closest to the desired hypothesis. Its function is to preserve the distinction established at the beginning of the program: evidence for experience, evidence for its absence, and evidence insufficient to decide are different scientific objects. Only after that distinction survives independent instrument validation, prospective passage construction, memory/access control, locked adjudication, and recurrence can the missing negative experiential anchor be said to have been earned.

10. Falsifiers and Failure Locus

A useful negative result requires more than a protocol capable of returning NEGATIVE. It also requires a clear account of what different forms of failure would mean. Without that separation, an unsuccessful experiment could be dismissed as a technical problem while a successful one was counted as support for the candidate object, making the architecture effectively self-protecting. The present design therefore distinguishes failures of the

experiment, failures of extended cessation as the selected target paradigm, and failures that bear directly on C3R.

10.1 Failure of the experimental architecture

The first class concerns whether the proposed program can construct and adjudicate the evidentiary object it requires. Stage A could show that the A–E instrument produces too many D responses when prior experience is independently established. Prospective entry and exit procedures could fail to yield protected cores with adequate temporal resolution. The memory/access controls could remain systematically failed or unresolved, or the controls themselves could disrupt the target condition. A candidate-independent adjudication rule might prove irreproducible, or timing and data-integrity failures might prevent passage-specific classification.

Any of these outcomes would pressure the experimental architecture. They would show that the present design cannot yet earn the negative experiential anchor it was built to seek. They would not, by themselves, show that current experiential standing cannot close or that C3R is false. The distinction matters because the experiment is an attempted measurement solution to a prior evidentiary problem. Failure of that solution returns the burden to experimental design rather than converting the absence of a measurement into a result about Consciousness.

Stage-A failure is the clearest example. If known-positive experiences are later misclassified as D at a rate incompatible with the frozen validation criterion, the dedicated negative datum has failed its intended job. The program should stop before the target experiment uses it. That outcome would be scientifically important precisely because it blocks an unsafe inference. It would not become evidence that no negative experiential passage exists.

10.2 Failure of extended cessation as the selected target

A second class becomes available only after the experiment itself is functioning adequately. Extended cessation is selected because its current experimental properties make it a promising route to the missing passage, not because C3R predicts that it must contain experiential absence. The target paradigm can therefore fail without the candidate object failing with it.

The strongest such result would be repeated POSITIVE standing in valid, prospectively bounded extended-cessation passages. If qualified practitioners repeatedly entered well-constructed target passages and admissible evidence established experiential presence

within the protected core, the tested form of extended cessation would not instantiate the sought whole-core absence. That would directly pressure its role as the leading negative-anchor paradigm.

Other results could pressure the target for different reasons. Extended cessation might prove too difficult to discriminate reliably from neighboring meditative conditions. Its transitions might remain too unstable for prospective passage construction, even if individual events are phenomenologically meaningful. Most importantly, independent evidence might support a target-specific form of selective amnesia capable of explaining otherwise admissible D responses despite intact memory and report functions around the core. In that case the negative route would close until the competing explanation could be resolved.

None of these outcomes should be described as a failure of C3R merely because extended cessation was chosen as the first serious target. C3R does not contain a claim that meditation must provide its negative anchor. A failed target would instead narrow the empirical search by showing that one plausible route does not presently satisfy the required discrimination.

10.3 Pressure on C3R itself

C3R is exposed to a different set of failures because its central claim is an identification: at the declared scope, Consciousness is treated as current experiential standing. Evidence that merely frustrates the proposed experiment is therefore insufficient. A C3R-level challenge must bear on that identification or on the distinct job attributed to the candidate object.

The most direct empirical pressure would arise if the same carrier and passage independently satisfied two incompatible warrants. Suppose one criterion, established independently of C3R, warranted that Consciousness was currently present while the experiential admission contract independently warranted that current experiential standing was absent. If both claims applied at the same level, scope, and passage, the identification of Consciousness with current experiential standing would face a genuine counterexample. The independent positive criterion would need to warrant Consciousness itself rather than a neighboring property such as processing, responsiveness, attention, integration, complexity, wakefulness, memory, or neural engagement. Otherwise the apparent conflict would simply reproduce the substitution problem that C3R was introduced to discriminate.

C3R can also fail structurally. If another same-level object were shown to carry the exact job assigned to current experiential standing such that removing C3R lost no relevant capacity, the present non-absorption result would fail. In that case C3R would no longer be needed as a distinct object at the declared scope. Likewise, if current experiential standing could be removed while the exact capacity attributed specifically to C3R remained fully available under

the accepted neighboring structure, the candidate's job and failure relation would be undermined. These possibilities matter even if no extended-cessation experiment is ever performed, because they test whether C3R earns its place as an object rather than merely whether one empirical paradigm can measure it.

The converse is also important. A passage in which experiential standing appears absent only because the carrier's standing capacity for Consciousness has also been lost does not instantiate the failure discriminant C3R is meant to test. Destruction, irreversible replacement, or another change that removes the relevant carrier capacity may produce absence of experience, but it does not demonstrate closure of current experiential standing while the capacity remains. Such a passage would therefore fail to answer the C3R question rather than serving automatically as either support or falsification.

These distinctions prevent the experiment from acquiring a one-way interpretation. A failed instrument pressures the instrument; an unusable passage pressures the protocol; repeated positive extended-cessation passages pressure the selected target; and an admissible conflict between Consciousness and current experiential standing, or a successful same-level absorption of C3R's job, pressures C3R itself. The proposal is informative because those outcomes have different consequences, not because they can all be redescribed as support. Keeping the failure loci separate allows a future NEGATIVE anchor, if one is earned, to carry evidentiary weight without making the architecture immune to failure.

11. Discussion

The central result of this work is not an observation of experiential absence. It is the localization of the evidentiary problem that has to be solved before such an observation can be claimed at the passage level. C3R gives that problem a deliberately narrow target: whether current experiential standing is instantiated in a particular consciousness-capable carrier during a particular passage. Once that target is kept separate from report, memory, responsiveness, content, state labels, and physiological proxies, the present empirical gap becomes more precise. Consciousness science already contains substantial evidence about states associated with reduced responsiveness, absent recall, altered complexity, dreamless reports, meditative cessation, and covert experience. What remains missing under the admission contract used here is a negative experiential anchor that survives the alternative routes by which those same observations can arise.

That distinction is intended to complement rather than displace current consciousness research. Recent work has increasingly moved beyond overt responsiveness as the sole evidentiary surface, using covert measures, within-state comparisons, real-time reporting,

perturbational and complexity measures, and other behavior-independent approaches to ask what experience may remain when ordinary report is unavailable.²⁴ Sleep research has likewise refined the difference between remembered experience, experience without retrievable content, and reports of no experience, while anesthesia research has made dissociations among responsiveness, experience, and later memory experimentally unavoidable.²⁵ The present proposal takes those advances seriously by asking a narrower question within them: when the scientific claim is specifically that no experience occurred during a bounded passage, what evidence warrants the negative rather than merely failing to warrant the positive?

This asymmetry has practical consequences for measurement. Much of consciousness science is understandably organized around detecting evidence that experience is present. A positive report, a prospective signal, a validated covert response, or another independently warranted indicator can defeat a claim of whole-passage absence when it is attributable to the relevant interval. The reverse inference is harder. Failure to obtain any one such signal may reflect absence of experience, but it may also reflect the limitations of the signal, memory, access, timing, behavior, or the experimental condition itself. The proposed admission contract therefore does not demand skepticism about physiological or behavioral evidence. It asks that non-detection receive only the inferential force for which it has been independently validated.

This is also why extended meditative cessation is useful even though its experiential status remains unsettled. The recent literature places a potentially long, endogenous, reversible target within reach of multimodal laboratory study and repeated within-participant observation.²⁶ Advanced meditation is increasingly being treated as a productive frontier for

²⁴ Samuel I. Kronemer, Peter A. Bandettini, and Javier Gonzalez-Castillo, “Sleuthing Subjectivity: A Review of Covert Measures of Consciousness,” *Nature Reviews Neuroscience* 26 (2025): 476–496, doi:10.1038/s41583-025-00934-1; An-An Ping et al., “A Methodological Guideline for Consciousness Assessment via Neural Electrophysiological Activity,” *Military Medical Research* 12 (2025): 90, doi:10.1186/s40779-025-00682-4; Tiziano Bertoni et al., “Multisensory Integration in Peripersonal Space Indexes Consciousness States in Sleep and Disorders of Consciousness,” *Cell Reports Medicine* 7 (2026): 102705, doi:10.1016/j.xcrm.2026.102705.

²⁵ Federico Siclari, Jessica J. LaRocque, Bradley R. Postle, and Giulio Tononi, “Assessing Sleep Consciousness Within Subjects Using a Serial Awakening Paradigm,” *Frontiers in Psychology* 4 (2013): 542, doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2013.00542; Giulio Tononi, Melanie Boly, and Chiara Cirelli, “Consciousness and Sleep,” *Neuron* 112(10) (2024): 1568–1594, doi:10.1016/j.neuron.2024.04.011; Kane O. Pryor, Yiping Jiang, and Jamie W. Sleigh, “Anesthetic Amnesia: The Forgotten Importance of Forgetting?,” *Anesthesiology* 143(3) (2025): 750–771, doi:10.1097/ALN.0000000000005544; Ishan J. Bajwa et al., “A Repeated Awakening Study Exploring the Capacity of Complexity Measures to Capture Dreaming During Propofol Sedation,” *Scientific Reports* 15 (2025): 32746, doi:10.1038/s41598-025-12695-z.

²⁶ Winson F. Z. Yang et al., “Endogenous Suspension and Reset of Consciousness: 7T fMRI Brain Mapping of the Extended Cessation Meditative Endpoint,” *bioRxiv* (2025), preprint, doi:10.1101/2025.09.06.674021; Kenneth Shinozuka et al., “Neuroelectrophysiological Correlates of Extended Cessation of Consciousness in Advanced Meditators: A Multimodal EEG and MEG Study,” *bioRxiv* (2025), preprint, doi:10.1101/2025.09.19.677455; David Zarka et al., “EEG Brain Reconfiguration During Meditation-Induced Extended Cessation of Consciousness: A Dense-Sampling Multi-Participant Microstate Study,” *bioRxiv* (2026), preprint, doi:10.64898/2026.02.10.705005.

consciousness research more broadly.²⁷ The value of extended cessation here does not depend on accepting the strongest interpretation of the state offered by practitioners or source authors. Its value is experimental: it may permit the same carrier to move from clearly positive experiential standing into a prospectively bounded target passage and back again without using a primarily amnesic pharmacological intervention to create the transition. That geometry makes the negative question unusually accessible while leaving its answer genuinely open.

The proposed Stage-A requirement follows from the same restraint. A post-passage judgment of complete experiential absence is potentially informative, but its evidentiary value cannot be established using the same unknown target passages in which it will later serve as the critical negative datum. Validating that judgment in independently known-positive, memory-challenged cases moves one important source of uncertainty outside the target experiment. It does not turn first-person report into an infallible instrument or show that D transfers unchanged across every altered state. Instead, it tests whether the particular error most dangerous to the negative inference—prior experience later reported as complete absence—occurs often enough to make the proposed datum unusable. Stage B then retains participant-level calibration and target-specific memory/access guards because transfer from the validation paradigm remains conditional. A failed Stage-A validation would therefore be substantive scientific information rather than an inconvenient preliminary result.

The program's outcomes also remain partitioned by what they actually test. Instrument failure, passage-construction failure, target-paradigm failure, an unresolved passage, an admissible negative anchor, and a C3R-level counterexample do not carry the same implication. Their scientific value depends on preserving those differences rather than redescribing every outcome as support.

The machine-auditable component serves the same discipline at the formal level: an open empirical burden remains open rather than being repaired by interpretation. The resulting NotYetAdjudicable disposition is therefore an auditable stop condition, not evidence for C3R. Because the exact kernel and Consciousness contract are part of the public reproducibility surface, readers can rerun the sources, inspect the encoding, and attempt to break the formal relation rather than accepting that stop on authority.

Structural Flow enters the paper at that methodological level. It did not provide the empirical evidence or determine the target outcome; its role was to discriminate the candidate object,

²⁷ Clarita Bonamino, Clara Hausen, and Matthew D. Sacchet, “Advanced Meditation, Sleep, and Consciousness Science: An Emerging Frontier,” *Neuroscience & Biobehavioral Reviews* 187 (2026): 106741, doi:10.1016/j.neubiorev.2026.106741.

its failure condition, and the point at which the evidence no longer licensed the next inference. The broader framework is not required to evaluate whether the resulting evidentiary burden and experiment are scientifically defensible.

That progression may itself be useful beyond the particular target chosen here. The present work moved from object discrimination to a failure signature, from the failure signature to an evidence contract, and from the unresolved contract to an experimental design. The significance of that sequence is not that it provides a universal recipe for consciousness research. Rather, it illustrates one way of preventing explanatory or formal structure from outrunning empirical admission. A framework becomes scientifically productive when it narrows what must be observed, distinguishes outcomes that would bear on different parts of the hypothesis, and leaves open questions open when the required evidence is absent.

The immediate consequence is therefore modest but concrete. C3R has not reached empirical closure, and the proposed program may never produce an admissible NEGATIVE anchor. What has been gained is a question with a sharper experimental form: can a consciousness-capable carrier traverse a prospectively bounded passage in which current experiential standing is absent, while memory, access, report, temporal localization, positive contradiction, and carrier continuity remain sufficiently controlled to make that absence the warranted interpretation? Existing evidence does not yet answer that question under the present contract. The staged program makes it possible to ask it without deciding the answer in advance.

12. Limitations and Open Implementation Burdens

The central limitation of the present work is also its organizing result: no admissible negative experiential anchor has yet been established under the admission contract developed here. The proposed experiment has not been performed, and the current empirical standing of C3R therefore remains unresolved. The architecture identifies what evidence would be required to move beyond that point, but it does not substitute specification for observation.

Several implementation choices also remain intentionally open. Stage A has a frozen methodological job and statistical operating point, but its validation platform and final participant-facing wording still require selection and testing. Stage B likewise has a fixed passage and control architecture while the executing laboratory must preregister the exact timing tolerances, guard margins, memory-task implementation, synchronized measurements, and minimum analyzable core. These are operational dependencies rather than missing theoretical steps, but they must be resolved before confirmatory data collection begins.

The same distinction applies to physiology. The proposed measurement package is deliberately broader than the standing classifier because EEG and other physiological streams may help characterize transitions, identify covariates, detect protocol failure, and generate mechanistic hypotheses. Exact preprocessing pipelines and confirmatory feature families have not yet been frozen, and no physiological threshold currently defines NEGATIVE. If a covert-positive measure or in-core sentinel is added, its evidentiary role would likewise have to be validated independently before target data are adjudicated. This preserves the separation between measuring a candidate mechanism and determining experiential standing.

Memory remains the most important unresolved alternative explanation on the negative side. The proposed guards test memory formation, later access, report competence, prospective task retention, and the participant's ability to distinguish forgetting from absence. They do not logically eliminate every conceivable form of selective amnesia. In particular, experience could in principle occur during the protected core while later access to both its content and the meta-memory that it occurred is selectively disrupted, even though surrounding memory functions remain intact. The relevant standard is empirical rather than logical exhaustion: a merely imaginable selective-amnesia mechanism does not by itself prevent adjudication, but independently supported evidence that such a mechanism is operating in the target condition does. The current protocol therefore withholds NEGATIVE when that competing explanation becomes materially live. The strength of any future negative anchor will depend partly on how well that residual alternative is pressured empirically.

The proposed target population also constrains generalization. Extended cessation is being considered in highly trained practitioners specifically because repeated endogenous entry into the target condition appears experimentally tractable in that population. A negative anchor in one or more such participants would establish a narrow existence-and-recurrence result. It would not determine how common the phenomenon is among meditators generally, whether untrained individuals can enter comparable passages, or whether similar experiential transitions occur during sleep, anesthesia, coma, or other states. Those questions would require separate studies with their own admission and sampling burdens.

The present extended-cessation evidence base should also be read with appropriate source-status caution. Several of the most directly relevant multimodal studies remain preprints at the time of this drafting and are used here primarily to establish experimental feasibility and expose methodological constraints rather than as final authority for experiential absence. Their eventual peer-reviewed versions, or later contradictory findings, could alter the preferred target implementation without by themselves changing the evidentiary distinction the experiment is designed to test.

The formal component is independently reproducible but remains bounded to its encoded scope. Public release of the kernel, Consciousness contract/adaptor, source hashes, and execution information makes the formal claims rerunnable and attackable; it does not make the empirical premises true or establish Universal Kernel completeness. The neural or physical realization of current experiential standing also remains open: a future NEGATIVE would not by itself identify its mechanism, just as a mechanistic correlate would not by itself establish experiential standing.

These limitations bound the contribution rather than defeating it. The present result is not an empirical closure of Consciousness, a prevalence estimate, a universal neural theory, or a solution to the broader philosophical problems associated with subjective experience. It is a narrower scientific advance: the negative evidentiary burden has been made explicit enough to distinguish what existing evidence already warrants from what a future experiment would still have to establish. That boundary is what allows the proposed program to fail cleanly, succeed narrowly, or remain indeterminate without changing the meaning of its outcomes after the fact.

13. Conclusion

A claim of experiential absence should require more than failure to detect experience. Report, recall, responsiveness, physiological signals, and state labels can each provide important evidence about consciousness, but none acquires the reciprocal authority to establish no experience merely by being absent. The problem addressed here was therefore passage-specific: what would have to be true before a bounded interval could responsibly be classified as one in which no experience occurred?

C3R provides a candidate object for asking that question by treating Consciousness, at the declared scope, as current experiential standing in a consciousness-capable carrier. Its scientific value does not depend on treating report, memory, behavior, physiology, or mechanism as equivalent to that standing. Instead, those quantities remain separate sources of evidence whose inferential roles must be earned. Applied to the current literature, that distinction leaves substantial evidence about candidate unconscious states while withholding a negative experiential anchor under the admission contract developed here.

The resulting stop is empirical rather than rhetorical. The formalization records the same boundary: the encoded object can be located, but the missing negative experiential witness cannot be supplied by structural coherence or machine execution. The exact kernel and Consciousness contract are publicly reproducible so that this formal relation can be

inspected, rerun, modified, or challenged independently. A clean formal result does not decide the empirical question.

That question now has a prospective experimental form. The staged program first tests whether the negative report can survive known-positive memory and access challenges, then applies the validated instrument to prospectively bounded extended-cessation passages, and finally adjudicates locked evidence under a rule fixed in advance. The architecture permits POSITIVE, NEGATIVE, INDETERMINATE, protocol failure, target failure, and C3R-level challenge to remain different outcomes rather than being collapsed into support for the same conclusion.

No experiment reported here has yet produced the negative anchor that C3R requires. Whether such an anchor can be earned remains open. The contribution of this work is to make that openness experimentally discriminable: a future result can succeed narrowly, fail at an identified locus, or remain unresolved without changing the evidentiary rules after the outcome is known.

The resulting question is therefore both smaller and harder than whether a state is ordinarily called conscious or unconscious: **can the same consciousness-capable carrier traverse a prospectively bounded passage in which current experiential standing is absent, while the evidence remains strong enough to distinguish that absence from forgetting, failed access, behavioral silence, proxy non-detection, and loss of the carrier itself?** The present evidence does not yet answer yes. It now permits the question to be tested.

Declaration of Generative AI and AI-Assisted Technologies

During the preparation and revision of this manuscript, the author used generative AI tools to assist with drafting support, language refinement, structural editing, protocol organization, consistency checking, and clarity. All substantive arguments, theoretical claims, experimental-design choices, scope decisions, and final editorial judgments are the author's own. The author reviewed and approved the final manuscript and takes full responsibility for its content.

Consciousness and Experiential Absence

An Evidentiary Contract and Staged Experimental Program

Signed,

Rick